

Recollection Talk — Part I, Chapter 1

"Consecrated Life Between Calcification and Conversion: A Theological Diagnosis"

A 45-Minute Recollection for Priests, Religious, and Major Seminarians — West Bengal Region

Based on: "The Ever-Evolving Consecrated Life" by Sr Inigo SSA — Part I, Chapter 1

In the theological voice of Fr. Joseph Lobo SJ

"Before I formed you in the womb I knew you; before you were born I consecrated you."
(Jeremiah 1:5)

⌚ TIME GUIDE

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OPENING: THE LIVED CONTRADICTION

(7 minutes)

By way of introducing, let me begin with a well-known theological affirmation — and then with the reality that contradicts it.

We say: consecrated life is a *sequela Christi* — a following of Christ in the most radical manner available to a human being. The Second Vatican Council in *Lumen Gentium* 44 describes it as a sign that "more completely" expresses the heavenly goods already present in this age and anticipates the life to come. That is the claim.

And now the reality.

In a five-year period documented by Vatican statistics, nearly fifteen thousand religious left their congregations — not, it must be noted, because they ceased to believe in God, but because they experienced no spiritual fulfillment within the structures designed precisely for that purpose. Parents who know religious life from the inside — who have lived alongside it, offered their sons and daughters to it — are now deliberately steering their children away from it. And in many of our congregations, the question of relevance is not raised at chapter meetings precisely because it is too uncomfortable to raise.

The gap between the claim and the lived reality — that is our problematic this morning.

And I want to say, at the outset, that this is not a problematic of bad people. It is a problematic of an institution that has, in many of its expressions, undergone a specific theological reversal — a reversal that I shall name and attempt to diagnose in the course of this reflection.

In one sentence, if I were to state the thesis of this entire recollection: **Consecrated life in Asia today is in crisis not because it has been abandoned by God, but because significant portions of it have substituted institutional maintenance for prophetic mission — and until this substitution is named, diagnosed, and reversed, no programme of renewal will touch the root of the problem.**

Let me now develop that.

PART I — TWO MODELS OF CONSECRATED LIFE

(10 minutes)

Sr Inigo SSA, whose reflection forms the basis of our recollection, opens with an image that I find theologically precise: she says consecrated life in Asia today is like **two sides of the same coin**.

I want to develop this image theologically. Because a coin has two sides, but it has only one substance — and the question is what that substance actually is.

The first model — and it is still alive, still real — is what I would call the *kenotic model* of consecrated life. It proceeds from a genuine divine encounter. It is characterised by what Pope Francis, in *Evangelii Gaudium* 20, calls going out of oneself — going toward the periphery, toward the margin, toward the place where the Kingdom is not yet visible. In this model, the vows are not juridical obligations to be observed but radical orientations of a life that has genuinely grasped its own vocation. Poverty is not mere simplicity of lifestyle — it is a theological statement about where ultimate value resides. Chastity is not merely celibacy — it is a form of universal love, unencumbered by possession or domination. Obedience is not submission to a hierarchy — it is an attentiveness to the *missio Dei* as it moves through history and community discernment.

In this first model, the congregation exists to serve the mission. The institution is at the disposal of the charism.

The second model — and this is what Sr Inigo's statistics document — is the *institutional-maintenance model*. In this model, the roles are reversed. The mission is at the disposal of the institution. The congregation's primary energy goes to managing its schools, hospitals, and properties — not because these are not good works, but because they have ceased to be expressions of charism and have become self-perpetuating structures. The young men and women who enter find, often after years of generous waiting, that what they are being formed for is essentially a professional role within a religious enterprise, not a prophetic vocation within the *missio Dei*.

And here is the specific consequence of the second model, which must be stated plainly.

First: the congregation loses the capacity for re-founding. It can reform — it can paint the walls, revise the timetable, add new programmes — but it cannot question the structures themselves, because the structures have become the identity of the group.

Second: a growing disinclination — and Sr Inigo uses precisely this word — develops toward ministry in slums, prisons, rural outposts, and among Dalit and Tribal communities. This is not a moral failure; it is a structural consequence. Institutions are conservative by nature. They tend toward the sustainable, the manageable, the prestigious. And in India, with its specific caste-inflected social hierarchy, "prestigious" and "marginalised" remain, almost by definition, mutually exclusive.

Third — and this is perhaps the most theologically serious consequence — the generation gap within congregations becomes a wound rather than a gift. Sr Inigo observes that congregations are now receiving candidates who are thirty-five to forty years old, people who have lived in the world and carry with them a history that does not fit neatly into the novitiate timetable designed for an earlier social context. And the older members of the community, who carry decades of faithfulness, sometimes hold so tightly to received forms that they inadvertently suffocate the very people they are trying to form. This is not malice. It is the structural logic of a model that has prioritized maintenance over mission.

I repeat the thesis: **the crisis of consecrated life is not a crisis of vocations. It is a crisis of models.**

PART II — THE THEOLOGICAL DIAGNOSIS

(12 minutes)

Let me now attempt a theological diagnosis. And I want to do this by recovering two words — two words that have undergone the same kind of reversal that has affected consecrated life itself.

The first word is *consecrare*.

In its Latin root, *consecrare* is a verb. It means to set apart for — not merely to separate from. The preposition matters. Consecration is not primarily about withdrawal from the world; it is about a directed, purposeful movement *toward* a reality that the world cannot provide for itself. When the Second Vatican Council in *Lumen Gentium* 44 speaks of consecrated life as a sign, it means

that the consecrated person is not a museum exhibit of holiness — they are a living signal, a *sacramentum mundi*, a visible transparency to what God intends for all of creation.

The problem is this: over the centuries, particularly from the post-Tridentine period onward, *consecrare* has gradually been converted from a verb into a noun. **Consecration** — the act of directed, ongoing, costly orientation — has become **the consecrated** — a status, a category, a legal condition. And when a verb becomes a noun, it loses its prophetic edge. It becomes manageable. Classifiable. Institutionalizable.

Walter Brueggemann rightly points out, in his analysis of the prophetic imagination, that every institution tends to domesticate the prophetic voices that gave it birth. The founder is eventually canonised — which is good — and then, subtly, the founder's charism is translated into manageable structures, which is precisely the moment when the institution begins to lose what the founder died for. This is not inevitable. But it requires a continuous act of retrieval — what Sr Inigo calls *re-founding* — to resist it.

The second word is *prophētēs*.

The Greek *prophētēs* means, literally, one who speaks *pro* — on behalf of, or in advance of. The prophet does not merely predict the future. The prophet reads the present in the light of God's project and names what must be named, regardless of the institutional cost. Abraham Heschel, the great Jewish philosopher of prophetic consciousness, says that the prophet is the one in whom God's pathos — God's passionate care for the marginalised — becomes theomorphic: it takes human form and speaks in a human voice.

Now, consecrated life was always meant to be prophetic in this precise sense. Not prophetic as a specialised vocation within the Church, but prophetic as a constitutive dimension of what it means to follow the God who, in Jeremiah 1:5, says: "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you; before you were born I consecrated you." Notice the sequence. The knowledge precedes the formation. The consecration precedes the birth. God's claiming of a life is always prior to the life's own understanding of itself.

But — and this is the diagnostic point — the prophetic dimension of consecrated life has been systematically weakened by what I would call the **clericalist-institutional complex**. Pope Francis, in his Apostolic Exhortation *Evangelii Gaudium* 102, names clericalism as one of the most serious pathologies of the contemporary Church. And clericalism — which is not limited to ordained clergy — is precisely the substitution of institutional power and prestige for prophetic mission. When a religious congregation begins to measure its success by the size of its campus, the prestige of its institutions, and the visibility of its members in elite circles, it has — however unconsciously — exchanged the prophetic for the clericalist.

Sr Inigo's seven-fold framework for renewal is, I would argue, a systematic reversal of this clericalist-institutional logic. Let me name the seven movements she proposes, but I want to name them theologically rather than merely descriptively.

From regularity to radicality: this is the movement from *observance* to *discipleship*. Observance is the fulfilment of obligations within a system. Discipleship is the continuous conversion of the whole person toward the one who said: "*Follow me*" — not: "*Observe the timetable*."

From rigidity to flexibility: this is the movement from *law* to *Spirit*. Paul, in 2 Corinthians 3:6, says: "*The letter kills, but the Spirit gives life.*" The Spirit moves where it will (John 3:8). A congregation that cannot move where the Spirit moves has substituted its own administrative convenience for theological attentiveness.

From withdrawal to involvement: this is the movement from *sacristy* to *world* — the movement that *Gaudium et Spes* 1 makes programmatic when it says that the joys and hopes, the griefs and anxieties of the people of this age, especially the poor and afflicted, are the joys and hopes, the griefs and anxieties of the followers of Christ.

From asceticism to advocacy: this is perhaps the most significant movement for the Indian context. Personal asceticism without social advocacy is, in the prophetic literature, a form of religious narcissism. Isaiah 58:3-7 makes this explicit. The people ask: "*Why have we fasted and You do not see?*" And God answers: "*Is not this the fast that I choose: to loose the bonds of injustice, to let the oppressed go free?*" Fasting is not for the glory of the faster. It is for the transformation of the conditions that make others fast involuntarily.

From renewal to re-founding: this is the distinction between *reform* and *reformation* — or, to use the more theologically precise language of the tradition, between *renovatio* and *metanoia*. *Metanoia* — which has been domesticated in English as *repentance*, when it actually means a turning of the whole direction of one's life — is not an emotional response. It is a structural reorientation. Re-founding does not mean abandoning the charism. It means returning to the charism so radically that the institutional accretions that have obscured it are cleared away.

From managers to animators: this is the movement from administration to mission — from running an institution to animating a community of disciples. Karl Rahner, in his analysis of priestly and religious solitude, says that the greatest temptation of the religious leader is to confuse being busy with being fruitful. Business — *negotium* — is the absence of leisure; and leisure — *scholē* — is the condition for genuine creativity and prophetic attentiveness.

From pious to prophetic: and this is the seventh and most difficult movement, because piety is visible and manageable, while prophecy is costly and often unwelcome. Max Weber, from a sociological point of view, is emphatic in distinguishing the priest from the prophet: the priest administers grace within a system; the prophet challenges the system in the name of grace. Weber intended this as a sociological distinction. In the theological tradition, it is a vocation — and the consecrated life was always meant to hold both. The tragedy is that in many of our congregations, the priestly-administrative function has entirely consumed the prophetic function.

PART III — THE SCRIPTURAL CONSTELLATION

(8 minutes)

I want to bring three scriptural texts into this argument — not as proof-texts but as witnesses, each adding a dimension that the others do not supply.

The first witness: Jeremiah 1:5-10.

"Before I formed you in the womb I knew you; before you were born I consecrated you; I appointed you a prophet to the nations."

And Jeremiah's response? *"Ah, Lord God! Truly I do not know how to speak, for I am only a boy."*

Notice what the divine call does not do. It does not wait for Jeremiah's competence. It does not begin with a formation programme. It does not consult the congregation's chapter. It begins with a prior knowing — a knowing that antecedes every institutional structure — and then it issues a commissioning that is, by its very nature, costly and socially dangerous.

The word *prophet* — *nabi* in Hebrew — carries a double resonance: one who is called to speak, and one who is carried along by the divine word, sometimes against one's own preference. Jeremiah, as we know, was not an enthusiast for his own vocation. He was, in the words of *Jeremiah 20:9*, one in whom the word became *"like a burning fire shut up in my bones"* — he tried to contain it and could not.

That is the theological texture of consecrated life at its most authentic. Not enthusiasm. Not institutional confidence. A fire that is not generated by the individual, and that the individual cannot finally suppress.

The second witness: Luke 5:1-11.

The scene is well known. Simon Peter and his companions have fished all night — with expertise, with commitment, with the knowledge of professionals — and have caught nothing. Jesus arrives and says: *"Put out into the deep water and let down your nets for a catch."*

The detail I want to draw your attention to is the word *deep* — *bathos* in Greek. Not *elsewhere*. Not *further along the shore*. **Deep**. It is an instruction about orientation, not merely about location. The deeper water is precisely where the professional fisherman's instincts say there is nothing to catch — and where the divine instruction says: go.

Peter complies. The nets break with abundance. And then — the detail that most readings pass over — Peter falls on his knees and says: *"Go away from me, Lord, for I am a sinful man."* He does not ask for more fish. He does not apply for a government subsidy. He encounters the holy — and is undone by it.

This is the *katabasis* that precedes all genuine mission: the going down, the recognition of one's own insufficiency, the encounter with the holiness of God that restructures one's sense of self. Without this *katabasis*, mission becomes management. And management — however competent — cannot do what only mission can do.

The third witness: Acts 1:8.

"You will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth."

Note the geographical logic. It begins *here* — in Jerusalem, in the place of familiarity and comfort and, incidentally, the place of the crucifixion. It moves through Judea — the wider culture, the known world. It passes through Samaria — the place of the other, the theologically suspect, the

socially compromised. And it reaches *the ends of the earth* — the frontier, the periphery, the place where the Church has not yet arrived.

This is the missionary logic of consecrated life: centrifugal, not centripetal. Moving outward, not consolidating inward. And in the Indian context — in West Bengal specifically — the ends of the earth are not geographically distant. They are Purulia. They are the slum-colonies of North Kolkata. They are the Dalit communities in Nadia and Murshidabad who have heard the Gospel and not yet seen its social consequences.

PART IV — THE PROPHETIC DEMAND

(5 minutes)

Sr Inigo's analysis of the post-COVID moment deserves separate theological attention, but I want to name it briefly here, because the pandemic is not merely a medical event. It is — as she rightly reads it — a *kairos*: a moment of disclosure, in which what has been hidden becomes visible.

Kairos is not merely a favourable moment. It is a moment that demands a response — a response that, if not made, does not simply delay things but actually forecloses a possibility. The tradition of *kairos*-theology, developed by Paul Tillich among others, insists that *chronos* — ordinary sequential time — flows within *kairos* — the depth dimension of time in which God's project is at stake. Missing a *kairos* is not like missing a bus. It is like missing a moment of grace whose specific shape will not return.

The pandemic disclosed six things that Sr Inigo names with theological precision. I shall summarise them in a different register.

It disclosed that **security is an illusion** — and that the consecrated life's deepest resource is not institutional stability but theological trust in the God who commands the sea (*Mark 4:41*).

It disclosed that **hierarchy is a fragile arrangement** — and that the Church's capacity to respond to crisis depends on the lateral bonds of community and mutuality, not on vertical chains of command that break down when the crisis is non-institutional in character.

It disclosed that **the ghetto mentality is not protection but privation** — that religious communities which had insulated themselves from the suffering world were precisely those least capable of responding to it with creativity and generosity.

It disclosed that **the vows are not private spiritual disciplines** — they are public, political, theological statements about what matters and what does not. A community that takes a vow of poverty and lives in structures that generate envy in the poor has not simply failed in personal virtue; it has made a contradictory theological statement.

It disclosed that **uniformity is not unity** — and that the linguistic, cultural, and theological diversity of our congregations in West Bengal — Bengali, Hindi, Santali, different regional traditions, different theological formations — is not a management problem. It is, theologically understood, a sign of the *catholicity* of the Church: *kath' holou*, according to the whole.

And finally, it disclosed that **the language gap in formation is a justice issue**. When candidates from rural West Bengal are formed entirely in English, when the theological library is inaccessible to those who think and pray in their mother tongue, the institution is not merely being inconvenient. It is — however unintentionally — replicating the colonial logic of a culture that measures intelligence by fluency in a language that is not one's own.

Until and unless consecrated life addresses this formation-justice question structurally — not merely with good intentions — the gap between the claim and the reality will persist.

SILENCE

(3 minutes)

(Speaker pauses. Sustained silence. Do not rush this.)

I want to leave you with one question — not five. One.

Not a question to be answered now. A question to be carried into prayer, into the conversation with God that will happen in the chapel this afternoon and in the hour before sleep tonight.

The question is this:

Which model of consecrated life am I actually living — and am I living it by choice, or by institutional inertia?

Do not answer quickly. Honest answers to theological questions rarely come quickly.

CLOSING PRAYER

God of Jeremiah, God of the burning fire that cannot be suppressed — You named us before we could name ourselves. You consecrated us before we had chosen anything.

And yet we have, in our better moments and our worse, made choices — about where to live, how to spend our days, what to build, what to protect, what to let go.

We confess that we have sometimes preferred the comfort of the institution to the discomfort of the charism. The security of the managed to the risk of the prophetic. The prestige of the visible to the obscurity of the margin.

We do not ask for easy conversions. We know what conversion costs — Jeremiah knew it, Peter knew it, Paul knew it, every serious follower of Yours has always known it.

We ask for honesty. The honesty to name what we are, and the courage to become what You called us to be before the institution had a form, before the congregation had a name, before the novitiate had a timetable.

Send us into deep water. And if the nets break — let them break with abundance.

Amen.

SPEAKER NOTES

Audience: Priests, Religious Women, Major Seminarians — West Bengal Region.

Register: This talk is written in the *academic formation talk* register of Fr. Joseph Lobo SJ — structured argument, theological rigour, prophetic sobriety, with pastoral warmth in the scriptural and closing sections. It is spoken, not read. The oral texture is built in: signposting, deliberate repetition, rhetorical questions held open.

Tone calibration: The talk does not manipulate emotion. It builds an argument and lets the argument do the work. The silence in Part IV is as important as anything spoken before it.

Pacing guidance:

- The Opening section should be delivered with deliberate slowness. Let the gap between claim and reality sit uncomfortably.
- The Two Models section (Part I) is the analytical heart. Move with precision, not speed.
- The Theological Diagnosis (Part II) is the most demanding section. Do not rush the etymological recoveries — they are doing theological work, not decorative work.
- The Scriptural Constellation (Part III) should feel warmer and more narrative.
- The Prophetic Demand (Part IV) should be delivered with controlled urgency — not emotionalism.
- The Silence is non-negotiable. Three minutes. Do not fill it.

Key theological moves to communicate clearly:

1. *Consecrare* as a verb, not a noun — ongoing direction, not acquired status.
2. The two models of consecrated life and their structural consequences.
3. The seven movements as theological reversals, not merely programmatic improvements.
4. The pandemic as *kairos* — a moment that discloses and demands, not merely disrupts.

Connection to Series:

- This Talk (Ch. 1): **Crisis and Call** — *What has happened to us, and what is being asked of us?*
- Talk 2 (Ch. 2–3): **Spirituality and Identity** — *Who is the God we follow, and how does that reshape our self-understanding?*
- Talk 3: **Mission** — *What does a re-founded consecrated life look like in West Bengal specifically?*